pancakes for dinner

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/42271578.

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Explicit

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Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra)

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by thedeafpomegranate

Summary

Amnesia AU - Catra and Adora have been living their happily ever after for eleven blissful years when tragedy strikes and a brain injury wipes everything from Catra's memory. Adora's left with a growing deadline and no semblance of a plan for getting their family back.

"We always have pancakes on Wednesdays," Adora speaks firmly, bracing herself for the objection to come, "Routine's important."

Glimmer smiles softly, though it doesn't reach her eyes. She moves over to Adora, a hand rubbing soft circles into her upper back. Adora pushes down the anger that bubbles illogically in her chest. It isn't Glimmer's fault that she's here instead of Adora's wife, or that Adora can hardly bear to be touched by anyone that isn't Catra. Anyway, she'd appreciated the support from her best friends until today; in its own way, it had almost felt helpful before the unimaginable had happened.

Notes

This lil three-parter has been rotting in my brain for months, but now that ResFlower has posted their Amnesia AU, I knew I absolutely had to get it on paper (well, screen ig) this evening so I can read theirs without self-consciously making their plot into my head canon! Anyhoos, in gratitude for the much-needed motivation, this has ended up as a gift for a wonderful writer :)

Named for one of my favourite tunes, 'pancakes for dinner' by Liz McAlpine - you'll see a fair few references to the lyrics in this fic.

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora watches as Catra steps forward in her green paramedic uniform, her breath suddenly slower and heavier than it usually is.

“Cat?” She can feel the anxiety building in her own chest in response to her flatmate’s demeanour, “What’s wrong?”

Catra stares at the floor as tears start to pool in her eyes, and it’s all Adora can do to pin her arms to her sides. She wants so badly to touch her, to offer comfort in a different kind of way, but it’s for the best if she doesn’t. If she does, Adora doesn’t know if she’ll ever be able to let go. And Catra… Well, Catra had made it clear that she wasn’t interested in the same kind of thing.

“I don’t wanna cross a line, Adora, but I have to say this.”

Adora gulps, not knowing what Catra could possibly be talking about. She’d barged into their shared apartment hours before Adora expected her to get home from work, foregoing the mid-week friends with benefits hangout Adora knew she’d planned. Really, Adora had never been quite sure whether she was grateful that Catra told her what she got up to with Lonnie. On the one hand, her flatmate’s openness was clear proof that their friendship was rock solid, no secrets - well, nearly none - between them. Yet on the other, it always ended in Adora sulking over her own lack of desire for casual sex; it ruled her well and truly out of Catra’s likely list of prospects.

“What is it?” Adora can feel her voice trembling in her throat and she’s almost surprised she managed to say anything at all.

“We started crash simulations today,” Catra starts, and Adora doesn’t know why she’s telling her this, as if Adora hasn’t listened to Catra

go over every hour of her air ambulance training schedule over the past week, “It was, like, really real. And I couldn’t stop thinking that if I did have a call-out and we crashed, or I never made it home-”

“Catra,” Adora interrupts her, nervous and confused all at once, “You’ve been set on being an air paramedic forever, don’t you-”

“Adora! I’m trying to tell you something!” Catra interrupts her this time and Adora almost feels guilty.

“Sorry.”

“It’s fine. Just… All I could think about was if I didn’t make it home and I hadn’t told you the truth, I’d never forgive myself.”

“If you were dead, you couldn’t forgive yourself anyway,” Adora hates herself for her nervous ramble, but it seems like she’s never been closer to her deepest, most repressed dream coming true and she doesn’t want to rip the plaster off and be disappointed like she always is in moments like this.

Catra frowns and Adora feels even worse. But she already knows that whatever’s going to come next will hurt so much more when it’s not what she really wants to hear.

“I need you to know this, okay? I’m probably going to regret this but I have to get it off my chest, if you’ll shut up for a fucking second.”

“I’m listening.”

Catra closes her eyes and inhales one last time before she looks up at Adora again, the intensity of her pupils boring into Adora’s face.

“I wanna make pancakes for dinner and watch TV with you forever, even if it’s under the covers when you’re sick.”

And there it was - all Catra wanted was to keep the status quo going, and of course, it's a familiar sense of dejection that hits Adora squarely in the chest.

“I want to go out at the weekend with you and get all dressed up just to get undressed and stay in anyway.”

“We already do all of those things, Cat.”

“Not the way I want us to.”

Adora’s breath hitches.

“Do you understand what I’m trying to say?”

Catra’s expression is almost desperate, and she’s somehow taken hold of Adora’s hand without her even noticing before. Adora nods, trance-like, and then magic happens. Catra waits for what’s maybe the longest moment in Adora’s life yet, and then she rises on her toes and brings her free hand to hover by Adora’s cheekbone. Adora mirrors her on instinct, tightening her grip on Catra’s hand as she feels Catra’s cheek make contact with her right hand. Her whole body feels like it’s warming up, molten chocolate flooding every inch of space inside her skeleton. They breathe deeply, static in the middle of a bridge that connects ‘before’ and ‘after’, and suddenly Catra’s lips press into hers. They’re even softer and sweeter than Adora had dared to imagine.

“You really want this?” is all Adora can say after her breath’s been stolen, “Me?”

Catra nods, more vulnerable and raw than Adora thinks she’s ever seen her before, “You?”

“Since always.”

This time it’s Adora who starts it, drinking Catra in as if she’s been wandering in the wilderness searching for water. It feels like she actually has, right up until this moment. Catra’s pulse pounds against the calloused fingers that have travelled to her jaw, a drum that commands Adora’s every move.

“Pancakes for dinner, then?” Adora speaks breathlessly when they finally break apart.

“Yeah,” Catra grins and it makes her gut tighten all over again, “Sounds good.”

—

Adora’s made pancakes every Wednesday night for more than eleven years. It never mattered how long her hours had been, or how much she craved something else for dinner;this was their tradition through the many years of dating, marriage, parenthood and all-around grown-up life that she and Catra had shared together.

She stares at the eggs on the counter in front of her, flour and butter and buttermilk laid out ready to be whisked.

“Adora?”

The strain in Glimmer’s voice makes her feel even worse. Adora forces herself to look up at her friend;there are greying bags under her eyes and her lilac waves have lost all their shape and volume. She’d feel sympathetic, if she didn’t know that she looked far worse herself.

“W ant me to order something in?” Glimmer walks over to her , “Bow’ s on his way with Finn.”

The thought of her three year old makes Adora’s stomach sink for the first time ever. She has no idea how she’s going to explain what’s happened to their kid. She can hardly understand it herself. Still, if motherhood has taught her anything, it’s that the show has to go on. Adora’s determined that there’s nothing she couldn’t push through for the benefit of her child;it seems ludicrous now that she ever

worried her mama bear instincts wouldn't kick in before Catra gave birth.

"We always have pancakes on Wednesdays," Adora speaks firmly, bracing herself for the objection to come, "Routine's important for them."

Glimmer smiles softly, though it doesn't reach her eyes. She moves over to Adora, a hand rubbing soft circles into her upper back. Adora pushes down the anger that bubbles illogically in her chest. It isn't Glimmer's fault that she's here instead of Adora's wife, or that Adora can hardly bear to be touched by anyone that isn't Catra. Anyway, she'd appreciated the support from her best friends until today; in its own way, it *had* felt helpful before the unimaginable had happened.

"It's been a really rough day, Dor. No one would expect you to carry on as normal." Glimmer's voice is impossibly soft, her usual purposeful tone missing in action, "Let me order something for you both. Our treat."

Adora steps back, fully intending to inhale but unable to stop the heaving sob that expels itself from her when she opens her mouth. She stifles herself with a shaking palm, but it doesn't make any difference. The eggs still stare back at her, taunting her for her weakness.

It's too much. Finally, she turns into her friend's embrace, her body melting in Glimmer's arms as wails push through her throat. Every touchpoint between them seems to communicate the same questions over and over again: *How could this happen? How is this fair?*

Glimmer stays silent for ten minutes once they sink to the kitchen floor; it's not until Adora catches sight of the time on the oven that she realises Bow will probably get home with Finn in less than five minutes. She has to be ready. It's the only reason she has for keeping herself from totally losing it.

"They cant see me like this,"Adora starts, "I better splash my face."

Glimmer nods, but she grabs Adora's hand before she gets up.

"Let me order in, honestly . I promise one week wont ruin everything, theyll think it' s a treat,"Glimmer waits for a response, but Adora feels so exhausted she cant say a thing, "W e havent ordered from Sushi Haven in forever, and you said Finn really likes the little bao buns they do."

"I cant have sushi."

Adora watches as Glimmer cocks her head. She and Catra hadnt planned on telling anyone yet but she doesnt have the resolve or the energy for excuses right now.

"I dont think Cat' s gonna hold it against us if we order her favourite," Glimmer takes a punt, and Adora wishes her hesitation really was down to something that innocuous, "W e can order it again when she's home."

Adora shakes her head. All she's wanted for days is to get Catra home, back where she belonged instead of wired up in that itchy hospital bed, Yet now she can barely imagine what it could be like now, let alone whether theyll ever get back to the point of ordering sushi platters. Adora never thought she'd crave being teased for her horrendous inability to use chopsticks this much. She'd taken it all for granted.

"How about pizza then?"Glimmer was changing tack, "She doesnt like it that much anyway."

"It' s not that."Adora can tell it' s now or never - at least for the foreseeable, "It' s the raw fish."

A pause, and then Glimmer gasps, her fist tightening around Adora's own.

"Dor , you're not"…

"Eleven weeks on Friday ," Adora' s words sound foreign even though she can feel her mouth shaping them in real time, "W e did the embryo transfer at the start of August."

Adora shudders, her head hitting the counter cupboards behind her when she leans back.

"What am I going to do? My wife thinks we're still roommates and bnnie' s her go-to for sex. She's got no idea we have Finn, or that we've got another one on the"…

Adora cant finish her sentence;she clamps her hand to her abdomen without thinking, the first time she's been able to do so outside of the intimate moments she's shared with Catra in solitude. All she can focus on is how horribly everything's likely going to turn out when she tries to explain it all to Catra tomorrow, or how much harder this is going to get when she starts to show. It's not just Catra's reaction that scares her;Adora cant bear the thought of everyone's pity raining down on her.

"W e've got you," Glimmer says urgently in her ear , "Besides, Catra' s going to remember, okay? That stubborn brain of hers is stronger than any stupid injury . I know it."

The doorbell rings three times in a row and they jump to their feet; Finn still hasn't stopped jamming the button when they hear the door unlatching, the heavy charm that Catra had insisted on adding to the spare set of house keys that Glimmer and Bow kept at home jangling in the air. When her toddler comes tearing through the kitchen and launches himself into Adora's arms, the smell of baby shampoo and wax crayon residue steadies Adora more than any lengthy explanations a doctor can give her.

"Mama home now?

"Not yet, nugget," Adora wishes it didn't feel like she was lying to her kid, "Soon."

She squeezes Finn again to prevent his pout from upsetting her too much, ignoring the concerned looks she knows are being exchanged between her two closest friends.

"Anyway , I've got a treat for you, Finny ," Adora starts, finally giving into logic, "For dinner , we're-"

"We're gonna watch Uncle Bow show off his fancy flipping skills!" Glimmer cuts in enthusiastically, her eyes widening at Bow as if she has to worry about him arguing back, "And you and your mum have got front row seats!"

Adora smiles at Glimmer weakly as Finn squeals with excitement, her gratitude met with a wink. The world had turned entirely upside down but at least one thing would graciously stay the same: pancakes for dinner.

Chapter End Notes

> What do you think of the set-up? And how on earth is Adora going to possibly break the news to Catra? I'd love to hear your thoughts - comments and kudos always appreciated! They really do make my day :)
>
> The next chapter will focus on Catra's POV and clarify some detail, as well as the start of her journey returning home.
>
> Thank you so much for reading!

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

> Whelp, obviously I started writing Chapter 2 and realised that this is not going to be a three-and-done escapade. So I guess it will be more than 3... 5? Maybe? We'll just have to see :)
>
> I was so grateful to see the response to Chapter 1 of this fic, and I hope this one will carry on punching you in the guts (in a nice way).

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra squeals when Adora lifts her up and spins her in the air, her first reaction to the email that's setting their future in stone. It's awkward with her waistband tightening against the bump that barely protrudes, but she clings onto Adora anyway, crossing her legs around her wife's hips for grip.

"I am so fucking proud of you, babe, but I'm gonna be sick if you don't put me down."

Adora gasps, setting Catra down on the carpet carefully.

"Better?" She leans down to kiss her, one arm wrapping around Catra's waist to pull them flush together.

"Much better," Catra says as she collapses onto the sofa in her pyjamas, grabbing Adora's phone to read the details of her new contract, "Especially now that I get to relax with my hotshot architect wife and enjoy a foot rub while watching 'Killing Eve'."

Adora groans as she's being pulled down to the cushions, but Catra knows she's not really upset when she's still grinning ear to ear, "It's so serious though! Plus, 'Love Island's on again tonight."

“You really wanna watch a bunch of vapid straights run around licking cream off each other?” Catra rolls her eyes when Adora nods enthusiastically, knowing exactly what’s to come.

“It’s a social experiment, Cat! And it’s shedding light on lots of common dynamics that happen in relationships.”

“Did you make that up or did Glimmer say it first?”

Adora needles her way into Catra’s lap, her head resting on Catra’s thighs so she can gaze up at her wife, “...Will you let me watch it if I say ‘yes’?”

Catra scoffs, digging her fingers into Adora’s hair to massage her scalp, “It wasn’t a ‘yes/no’ question.”

Adora pouts and Catra’s totally done for, “Fine, you win! But only because you just landed a massive client and I’m probably gonna fall asleep anyway.”

“Yes!” Catra can’t help but laugh at the ridiculous face her wife pulls when she pumps her fist in the air in victory, “I love you, light of my life and mother of my child.”

“Yeah, yeah, Romeo.”

After they swap positions, it’s no surprise that she falls asleep within ten minutes, though it’s a little too familiar when Adora starts to notice Catra’s twitching getting worse. She’s only seconds away from rousing her when Catra jolts awake sharply, her chest heaving with exertion.

“Catra? You feeling okay?”

“Yeah,” Catra pants, her eyes wild and unfocused as she pushes herself upright, “Just another bad dream.”

Adora worries her lip and pauses the TV, her arm stretching out to rub gentle circles on Catra’s back. It’s the sixth day in a row that

Catra's woken from her sleep like this. She passes her wife a glass of water from the sideboard, smoothing waves of thick hair out of her face.

"Was it the same one again?"

Catra nods, a little nervous. She sips at the water, hesitant to relive it all over again. But there's no way to erase the scene of her foot slipping off the edge of the peak before her colleagues' horrified eyes; nor forget the scream that Catra feels more than she hears as it rips its way from her chest to her throat, her frenzied breath seizing against the frosty sky.

"It has to mean something," Catra can't look at Adora as she says it, her voice barely audible. She's spent her whole adult life swearing off the supernatural beliefs of her parents, but since this dream has begun to repeat itself, she's started to wonder whether her commitment to logic has been misplaced, "There's no way this is just a coincidence now. "

"I'm sure it's a normal symptom, love," Adora's touch is grounding, but it can't prevent the tremble that ripples through Catra's body, "Didn't we read that it was normal to get vivid dreams?"

Catra turns to Adora, her fingers clamping onto her wife's palm in a vice grip, "What if it's a sign I should stay on the ground after my mat leave? Maybe with your new contract, we could afford it if I ask to be reassigned... I don't want to get hurt on a helicopter call-out and leave you. Or them."

Adora holds the silence, twisting in her seat to cup Catra's jaw with one palm, the other moving to rest gently over the hand that Catra has clasped to her belly.

"You do everything by the book, don't you?" Catra has to nod at that, she's always as careful as she can be on the job, "The best thing you can do for me and our baby is to carry on doing what you love. I

know you'll keep yourself safe - look what you've done already to make sure you and little bean are okay."

Catra exhales shakily. It's true that she's disclosed her pregnancy far earlier than most paramedics do to discount her from the air ambulance rota. Plus, she's known for being an absolute stickler for safety, even helping to train new starters on best practice in emergency protocols.

"It's just a dream, not a premonition," she chants at Adora rather than speaking to her, "That's all it is."

She burrows into her wife's chest, insisting that Adora puts the TV back on. Nevertheless, Catra can't quite shake the feeling that there's more to all this, especially given the frequent consistency of her visions. It's only Adora's arm around her shoulders that eases the tension in her bones, the warm pressure of her wife's palm over her womb reminding her that she has to trust what she can see in the corporeal world first. Anything in the vast beyond would simply have to wait.

It's a little too early in the morning for anyone to visit but Catra's been awake for hours, waiting for something other than blankness to hit her. The past few days have crept past her painfully slowly while racing all too fast, and Catra still hasnt got a handle on the pace of time ticking. She scoffs at herself when she thinks about it - if nothing else, time has made her into a þker and a fool.

The basic facts dont feel connected to her at all. She' s desperate to feel the weight of all these forgotten years in her brain, but all Catra feels properly sure of is that she's got another six months of training before shell be on the air ambulance crew full-time, and that every time she fucks some girl, she's imagining Adora gasping for release

under her. What she's been told by everyone else - that she had ten years of helicopter emergency work behind her before the fall, and that she's freaking *married* to the one person she's longed forever to kiss - just doesn't add up. The universe wouldn't be so cruel to let all her dreams come true and strip her of their sweetness, would it?

Catra supposes, given the circumstances, that it would.

She stares up at the ceiling, letting her hands wander under the covers for the billionth time. So much remains familiar: the small cluster of raised moles above the point of Catra's left elbow;the moisturised silkiness of the sternum tattoo she got at nineteen;the downy hair that's always stood out on her forearms, a childhood reminder that people like her weren't like most the other kids at school. There's plenty that's changed too. Her skin gives more, pulling away from the bone and springing back with less urgency than she expects, the pliable softness of her thighs rippling under her palm while hollowed stretch marks streak tiny valleys on the surface of her breasts, her belly and around her hips. Catra's pulse always spikes the most when she slips further down to her pubic bone, the pads of her fingertips grazing a thin foreign scar .

She doesn't like to dwell on it too much, although she can't think of any reasonable explanation other than the obvious. It makes little sense - surely, Adora would have mentioned something by now.

Catra's breath hitches when Adora comes to mind. She draws her left hand out from under the covers and holds it in front of her, fixated on the opal ring and simple gold band on her finger. She'd jammed them on as soon as the nurses told her that they were really hers; she'd barely been awake for a day then, and her head hadn't stopped spinning from everything. Yet she'd felt no hesitation when the rings slid onto her finger so smoothly. It was almost triumphant - Catra was sure they must have been professionally resized to fit so well - and it gave her the proof she needed. However much Adora wanted to pull off a prank, this one had gone way too far to just be a joke. It was too personal - Adora had inherited the inset stone from

her late grandmother and rarely took it off, but it would be far too small for her flatmate if it fits Catra's smaller finger now.

Not flatmate , Catra reminds herself, *Wife.*

Her hand's still splayed in the air when she hears someone clearing their throat. It's Adora, standing in Catra's room hours earlier than she's supposed to be, clad in yet another baggy Americana jumper . Catra cant help but reach out towards her . It's not quite *her* Adora who's hovering in the doorway, but this version has already skipped the difficult conversations Catra's been terrified of starting. This Adora is *in love* with her, and if Catra wants anything right now, it's to sink into the fantasy of belonging that she's yearned for.

Catra watches Adora intently when she treads carefully from the doorframe to the bed, taking stock of Adora's body like she has been of her own. Adora's clearly still athletic - she's deceptively muscular as well as slim - and her blonde hair's no different in texture even though it hangs in a bob around her jaw instead of being swept into a high ponytail. It's only a few more wrinkles and a softened roundedness to Adora's face that she doesnt recall - instead, Adora's physicality reveals most about how much has shifted between them. It's the confidence with which Adora smiles at her when she forgets for a split second why theyre in the hospital, and the memory of how freely she took Catra's hand in hers when she first woke from the coma. Catra wishes she didnt feel so self-conscious when she demands Adora come closer, but she's convinced shell screw everything up by saying the wrong thing. After spending so long with a devil on her shoulder holding her love confession back, Catra struggles to believe that her desire can really be reciprocated so deeply. Regardless, it would be entirely understandable if Adora doesnt really want Catra anymore, not when she must measure up so poorly to the 2022 counterpart that Adora's shared her life with.

Catra blinks back her concerns when she feels Adora's weight settle at the foot of the bed, her skin tingling with shy excitement.

"How did this happen?" Catra wiggles her ring finger in Adora's face, "Like, I never thought it'd be possible."

"Oh," Adora blushes and when she scoots a little further up the bed towards her, Catra suppresses the urge to lean forward and touch her just to see what would happen, "Well, like I told you, we were both pretty useless for a while. I can dig out some photos tonight, maybe that'll help you"…

Adora's voice trails off and she turns to stare at her lap, clearly fighting back tears. Catra frowns - it's not the effect she intended to have, but she's utterly clueless about making it better. There's no guarantee that a photo will trigger anything in her memories, and given that she's yet to show her any, Catra's sure that Adora's terrified it won't. She tries again to make her point instead of overthinking everything;concentrating too hard will only tip her dull headache into nausea.

"That's not what I meant, really. This is legit, right? Like, legally?"

There's a sharp intake of breath before Adora returns her gaze to Catra, somehow even more crestfallen. Catra can tell that Adora's berating herself internally, like she should have already realised it wouldn't be obvious.

"Yeah," Adora's sniffling now, her voice strained against unshed tears, "It passed in 2014 and we got married the year after."

"It's gonna be legal *that* soon?" Catra reels from the shock of it, "Next you'll be telling me they let the gays donate blood!"

"They do, actually. But that was back in 2011."

"It changes *this year*?" Catra almost yells, and she wonders whether all this means that she and Adora usually walk hand-in-hand down the street without concern, or if they can talk freely about their relationship without any awkwardness or worse, "That's crazy."

Adora hums under her breath and it reminds Catra that she's let the facade slip again - she's not meant to still be thinking it's 2011 anymore, "Yeah, I guess it kinda was."

"Did our parents come? To our wedding?" The second question slips past her lips before Catra stops it, the tremble in her voice giving her trepidation away too easily.

"Mine did," Adora speaks slowly and - *at last* - she finally takes Catra's hand in hers, "It took yours a little longer to get to grips with it. I'm not saying it's always easy, but they were honestly amazing when we got pr-"

She freezes, eyes widening.

This is it, Catra realises, *the point of no return.*

"What?" Catra says, suddenly impatient. She's sick of being drip-fed information and her suspicions weigh impossibly heavily, "Tell me."

"It's big, Cat," Adora's voice is quiet and streaked with nerves, "I want to do this right."

"You will," Catra tugs on her hand, silently begging Adora to come closer, "Please. I can handle it, I promise."

Adora finally perches right by her and Catra brings their intertwined fists to her wife's thigh. It's strange but nice, being able to touch her like this so freely. Adora sighs warmly, like she's been waiting for this contact forever. Maybe, for Adora, it feels like she has.

"We. We have a child, Catra. A three year old."

Catra closes her eyes. There's satisfaction in knowing she hasn't lost her sanity but she can't come to terms with it straight away - neither their reality nor Adora's omission. She pushes down the anger that feels like it could simmer under her skin if she lets it.

"Cat? Are you okay?"

Her eyes fly open, and she's almost shamed by the fear she can see reflected in the blue irises hovering before her, "Yes, yes. I... carried for us, didn't I?"

"You remember?" The disbelieving hope in Adora's voice is painful to hear, "You know about Finn?"

Finn… It rolls around Catra's mouth anew, but it doesn't feel familiar. Not enough.

"My body's different, Dor. I worked it out," Catra admits, wishing she hadn't let this wait for so long, "I'm sorry. I should have asked already, but I"…

Catra doesn't know how to admit that she'd been too scared of either outcome to seek an answer: she'd not been sure if it were worse to forget their child, or to learn her mind was playing cruel tricks on her, wrenching her unspoken hopes out into the open.

She never finishes her sentence. Adora pales during the silence, though she recovers quickly and smiles at Catra stiffly. There's no denying how much their situation has worsened now that Catra sees it in full, and her heart cracks when she reflects on what Adora might be going through without her at home. Suddenly, Catra's desperate to cheer Adora up, even if she can only do it for a few minutes. She figures that Adora's the kind of mother who could gush about her kid non-stop, always overjoyed by the tiniest, least impactful things. She's seen it when responding to parents on call-outs; asking questions about children is often the easiest way to distract or placate them.

"What's Finn like? Does he look like me?"

"Just like you," Adora starts, and Catra knows she's played her cards right, "You should know - they were born male, but we decided not to use any gendered pronouns until they're ready to tell us who they are. And they haven't yet, so."

"Oh," Catra's head spins a little, but she likes the sound of their decision, "That seems very modern."

"It was your idea! You said that no-one was putting your kid in a box based on their junk."

Catra grins, "I'm pretty cool, aren't I?"

Adora laughs, finally, and Catra realises it's the first time she's seen this many wrinkles crease at the edges of Adora's eyes. She lifts her hands to her own face, feeling the same folds by her eyelids as she chuckles. When she stops, she can see Adora watching her with fondness. There's never been much that Catra wouldn't do for this woman, and letting herself see that the reverse is true astounds her.

"There's something else," Adora says all of a sudden, and it's like the air cools again around them.

"Later," Catra answers without thinking, her eyelids already flickering shut after the effort of staying awake so far, "Will you stay?"

"Of course," she can hear that Adora's voice sounds pinched, but her body is already drifting off, "Always, Cat."

As sleep sweeps in to take her, Catra wonders if she'll ever be able to live up to her other self, the 'real' Catra who Adora loves; who's already a wife and a mother, and has ten years of air ambulance experience under her belt. Or, maybe, she hopes, she'll be lucky enough to remember it all. Catra doesn't think she's ever wanted anything more than she wants to share Adora's memories with her.

It's easier to dwell on this new craving than it is to acknowledge the truth that hurts too much: the old Catra is gone forever; the best they can hope for is something close to her.

Chapter End Notes

So, Adora's apparently quite good at her job and Catra still isn't entirely up to speed! How do you think her return home will go? And what did you think of Catra's nightmare? I would love to hear your thoughts and please do kudos if you are enjoying all this angst :)

Side note: I went to a kabbalistic town once while touring - the original type of Kabbalah from like 1CE, not the vibey celebrity one that got really big in the noughties - and it is super into dream interpretation as part of its mysticism so I guess Catra's parents are into that? (Did I accidentally make Catra Jew-ish again? Apparently). Ramble over , promise.

Next chapter will focus on baby steps (get it?) for our reforming family of three.

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

> You may be about to read the most self-indulgent scene I've ever written, but can't deny I had fun. Hopefully you'll figure everything out (I tried to pick the words that English/Yinglish speakers use rather than anything obscure, and tbh I only know the words that are common in English-speaking families anyway, we switched over around the 1930s?) I'll put some vocab in the end notes for you just in case :)
>
> Anyway, I am so enjoying writing this little fic and it's taking over all my lunch breaks. I hope you enjoy this chapter too!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora can't help but chuckle when she sees her wife obstinately clutching an oversize lamp, struggling to wrap its long cord over her stomach and around her wrist as she climbs the stairs. She's about to call out to her, but her father-in-law beats her to it.

"Catraleh, do you have to make everything so hard on yourself? Just let your wife do the schlepping."

"Tatti-"

"Maybe you should listen to him," Adora smirks at Catra when she looks up in surprise, a scowl of betrayal cloaking her features, "We're almost done, just relax."

"You've done everything," Catra retorts through gritted teeth, "And I'm not an invalid."

"You're meshuggeh, let her do it!" Catra's eyes roll as her mother's voice rings out from the upstairs landing, "Adora's a mensch, she knows what's best."

“I’m a mensch,” Adora beams, reaching up to Catra and teasing the lamp away from her.

“Do you even know what that means?”

Adora shrugs, sticking her tongue out when Catra’s dad rests a hand on her shoulder, “It means you’re a stand up bloke, Adora.”

“Oh my God, Tatti!”

Even though their relationship has been rocky at times, Adora loves having her in-laws Miri and David around - at least in small doses. No-one winds Catra up more than her parents, and seeing her regress into a petulant teenager with a bump as big as the one she sports now is more amusing than she’d ever admit to her wife.

“Come on, she built the place! With her own two hands!”

“Hey, I made half the decisions. Besides, she didn’t build *the place, she* designed *it.”*

“Oy, what’s the difference? Can you *build a house? No. Can I build a house? No! So stop kvetching so much about it. You should be happy you married someone that smart. You know Sol and Esther?”*

“The ones from our building!” Miri appears at the top of the stairs now, bubble wrap spilling out of her arms, “Oh, you wouldn’t believe how delicious her cakes are, honestly, she’s digging my grave with all these coffee invites she sends me-”

“Mame, what are you getting at?” Catra heaves herself to the top of the staircase and takes the bubble wrap from her.

“I’m getting there, if you’ll let me!”

“Your mame’s obsessed with Esther’s cakes,” Adora’s mind whizzes as her concentration flips back to Catra’s dad, “Anyway, anyway - Sol? His daughter-in-law’s a putz Jewish, sure. But by all accounts, she’s missing a couple of brain cells.”

“What has that got to do with anything?” Catra asks wearily, though Adora can tell she’s enjoying herself more than she’s letting on.

“Well, they’re the only other ones with lesbians,” Catra’s mother answers, “So it’s nice we got the good one. People talk.”

“Isn’t Becca’s wife a coder?”

“Pssht. What even is that, coding?” Adora pushes her lips together to stifle her amusement when David speaks, “An architect is much better than a coder-er. She built you a house, Catraleh!”

“A house!”

Adora laughs at Catra’s face when she catches sight of her expression, her brow furrowed in faux annoyance, “I did kind of build you a house.”

“I could literally kill you right now, Adora.”

Adora races up the stairs and kisses Catra on the cheek as she passes her, setting the lamp down in the bedroom next to the cot. There’s only some decorative stuff to bring in now - the movers had unpacked their furniture earlier in the week, and Adora’s spent hours getting the house ready for them leading up to this day. She turns around and catches Catra rubbing her back in the doorway, her silhouette taking up most of the frame.

“You okay, Cat?”

Catra nods slowly, rolling her shoulders back. Adora has spent most of the pregnancy trying to convince her to take it easy with little success. It’s only now that they’re barely weeks away from their due date that Catra’s starting to show any signs of slowing down. She moves across the room to squeeze her wife’ s hand, resting their foreheads together.

“We’re nearly done, love,” her voice seems suddenly thunderous in the new quiet, the two of them alone in their new bedroom, “And after tomorrow, they won’t be back until the baby’s born.”

Catra sinks into Adora’s embrace, giving over as much of her body weight as she can.

“I don’t mind it anymore, really. Not as much as I expected.”

“Can I confess something?” Catra quirks an eyebrow at Adora’s question, “I kind of love having them around.”

Just like clockwork, Catra’s mum interrupts again before they speak any further.

“Bubbeleh, will you go and sit now? I’m getting tired just looking at you.”

“Okay, okay!” Catra yells, her eyes rolling so far back into her head that even Adora laughs a little, “But I’m only doing it to make you feel better.”

Adora hurries after her as she makes for the staircase, biting her lip at Catra’s melodramatic grumbling under her breath. She hovers behind her wife cautiously as she descends, each laborious step taken one after the other.

“For fuck’s sake, just go past me! You’re driving me mad!”

“Language!” Catra’s parents call after them from opposite ends of the house at the same time.

“It’s - my - fucking - house!” she snaps back with exertion, prodding Adora as they get to the bottom step, “And you! I’m fine *.”*

Adora puts her palms up before her chest in surrender, letting Catra lead the way to the kitchen. She watches as Catra lowers herself onto their dining bench with difficulty, the warning glare shooting

from the brunette's eyes stopping her from rushing forward to support her.

"There!" Catra announces in triumph as she settles back in her seat, "Right. What are you going to make for me?"

"I thought you were totally fine and didn't need any help?" Adora teases, snorting at the flabbergasted gasp she gets in response.

"Miri, she's hungry!" David roars as he joins them from the living room and sits down next to his daughter.

"I'm coming, I'm coming!"

Catra groans, her hands braced on her belly, "Tatti, we've talked about this. You can't just shout for Mame every time someone wants something, it's degrading."

"She loves to feed you when we visit. You barely let her."

"It's-"

"Hetty-nome-additives, you told me," he signals for Adora to sit with them, "Forgive me, darlings, I'm an old man."

"I don't care, you're not doing that around our kid."

"Okay. I hear you," David concedes eventually, taking Catra's hand in his gently, "I'll work on it, Catraleh."

Adora smiles, the pleasant interaction a far cry from the blazing arguments that Catra had suffered with her parents when they were younger. The calm conversation that follows as Miri busies herself, spreading schmear on bagels and fussing over everyone at the table, feels like it's taking place in a whole other century. Adora knows that Catra used to pretend that she didn't want this, that the overbearing habits and rituals of her family had irreversibly driven her away. It warms Adora's heart to see how much has changed on both sides over the past seven months, from Catra's newfound

openness to compromise and her in-laws' overdue acceptance of their daughter's life. Above all, Adora's grateful that their child will have two sets of grandparents to lean on now, and two cultures to enrich them. It isn't what they'd expected in the years gone by, but time - alongside plenty of emotional labour - had proven itself to be a greater healer than they'd envisioned.

Adora inhales nervously as she jams the key in the front door of their house, her left hand secured tightly around Catra's own.

"I dont know why Im so jittery , Cat," Adora knows she's lying through her teeth but says it anyway, "You helped design this place!"

Catra squeezes her palm around Adora's fingers in response; for a second, Adora can suspend belief and pretend that it's just like any other instance, the two of them returning home after a busy day. The fantasy melts away quickly when she hears Finn squealing from their living room, his joyous shrieks echoing down the hallway when they enter. This had been her life for the past fortnight since Catra woke, shuttling between the hospital and her home while her child is cared for by others. Today, all of it is about to collide.

Once they've crossed the threshold and the door is shut carefully quiet behind them, it's clear how Catra's excitement fizzes around them, her weight shifting from foot to foot as she restrains herself.

"This is ours?" Adora's heart spikes a little with relief and pride at the awe in her wife's voice, "The whole house?"

She nods as Catra finally wanders ahead of her, her fingers drifting over every surface - mirrors, framed photographs, artworks that they'd both chosen and been gifted. Adora's breath hitches a little every time Catra pauses in front of a family photo. Even though

nothing she's been shown has sparked anything yet, Adora can see how hard Catra concentrates when she scours every tiny detail of an image.

"It's not much, but we're happy here."

"Not much?" Catra scoffs, "This place is, like, ten times the size of our rental. And these frames aren't even IKEA!"

"Yeah," Adora chuckles, "You really don't like IKEA anymore."

Catra hums, her singular focus on the wall decorations punctured by a chortling scream from the next room, "Mama home!"

Adora sees Catra stiffen, her eyes widening as they make contact again. She wonders whether it was the wrong decision to insist that Finn shouldn't come to the hospital to visit Catra, concerned that the unknown environment would make a difficult first meeting even worse. More than that, Adora wishes that she hadn't had to make the call alone - it was perhaps the first significant decision concerning Finn that Adora had made without her wife.

"Ready?"

Catra nods, tucking her hair behind her ear as Adora passes her to show her the way to the living room. She hopes that all the FaceTime conversations she set up between the three of them help this go well; at the very least, the onslaught of questions Catra had asked her about Finn between every call ensured that there was far less ground to cover between them. It feels like Adora's drifting, though she's tethered immediately to the moment when she feels a tiny body wrap itself around her legs urgently, a little face burying into her thighs.

"Hey, Finny," Adora crouches down to embrace her child, smiling gratefully in thanks to Bow and Glimmer for staying with them all morning, "Guess who wants to say hello?"

They pull apart from Adora's hold hesitantly, looking up shyly at Catra. It's like watching a mirror, every cautious expression reflected identically between mother and child. The saving grace is that Catra swallows her apprehension quickly;she winces a little as she lowers herself carefully onto a high-backed armchair - the one she spent long, arduous hours of her labour leaning on before their midwife called time - and stretches her hands forward, palms facing upwards and open.

"Mama?"

Catra is statue-still as Finn observes her from their unmoving vantage point, although her eyes flit over to Adora in a panic.

"It' s okay, baby. Go on."

Their toddler wanders across the rug, placing his hands in his mother's palms. They wait for her to scoop them into her lap, their brow crinkling in confusion at the lack of immediate affection. Adora realises instantly that for all the hobbies, likes, dislikes, loves and hates she'd briefed her wife on, she' s failed to prep Catra on the one thing she assumed would kick in all on its own: instinct.

Finn starts to push onto Catra's knees, clambering onto her lap of their own accord. They nuzzle into her chest, and Adora thinks she might stop breathing if Catra doesn't do something soon to soothe them. But then it's like life suddenly wakes within her and she wraps her arms around Finn, sweeping blonde wisps and curls out of their face.

"Hey , Finn. I missed you."

Adora isn't sure if it' s true when Finn giggles in response - she can't tell if Catra's convinced herself she would miss Finn, if she actually has yearned for them between video calls, or if they're miraculously coming to the end of this nightmare. She gets her answer quickly enough.

"You're even cuter than you were on video, huh?"

"It's cutest! That's what you always says!"

Catra chuckles, exploratorily winding the ends of Finn's long hair around her fingers, and Adora wishes seeing the interaction between them makes her feel better rather than worse. It's sweet, but it's nothing close to what she'd been holding out for. It hasn't mattered that she's told herself over and over that traumatic brain injuries are more often slower to heal than they are quick, and that there's no reason why this should be going any better than it is. Still, her heart already breaks from the absence of a happy Hollywood ending.

Her anguish worsens further when Adora puts Finn to bed that night, their legs curled up by the near imperceptible slope of her belly, and they interrupt their favourite storybook halfway through.

"Mama head stills poorly," Finn frowns, their pudgy fingers stroking Adora's arm, "She nots cuddle good."

"It might take a while, baby. But Mama was so happy to come home, she'll learn to give the best cuddles again."

Finn sniffles, and the lump in Adora's throat swells painfully.

"You know we love you, Finny? More than anything."

"More than birds in the sky!"

"And fishes in the sea."

She loves how her kid's face crinkles when they giggle, their nose smushing into her chest. It makes it that much easier to tuck them in and turn their bedroom light off, leaving only the glowing moon night light on before she leaves.

Adora braces herself for the next goodbye of the night - but instead of finding Catra in their bedroom, she's sat cross-legged on the guest bed that Adora has set up for herself in the loft.

"What are you doing up here, Catra?" Adora focuses on folding the towels she'd dumped hurriedly on the dresser before picking Catra up from the hospital, "You should sleep in our bed, it's far more comfortable."

"I don't care about that. I want to sleep with you," Adora's taken aback by her wife's jitters - it's at times like this she remembers she's got a younger, less mellow version of Catra again, "Not *sleep with you,* sleep with you, though obviously, I'm sure that's great. Or you're great. Fuck."

"It's okay," Adora laughs, cocking her hip as she turns to look at her, "I wish I'd known you were this thirsty before we got together. I might have made a move first."

She reaches out for Catra, only for her wife's face to fall; Adora hasn't seen Catra looking this upset since she first was told of her amnesia. Or maybe, Adora wonders, she just hasn't felt capable of looking hard enough for it.

"I can't figure it out," Catra says finally, "Why then? Why couldn't my memory reset after they were born, or we were married?"

"Catra"…

"I missed everything."

Adora kneels at the foot of the bed, clasping Catra's hands in hers, "You didn't miss it. You're the best, most amazingly present wife and mum that anyone could ask for. It'll get better soon, I promise."

Catra's face twists; Adora can already tell her pleas aren't hitting the mark.

"That was *her*, not *me*. And you can't promise that. What if nothing comes back to me?"

Adora can't process the start of Catra's sentence, so she focuses on the words that she's already planned an answer to a billion times in her head.

"We'll make new memories. All of us."

"I don't remember giving birth to our kid, Adora! Or anything about him. We made a family, but all I've got is a stupid list of random facts in my head. That's it! And I know he can tell," Catra cries, her whole body shrinking into itself, "What new memories are going to make up for that?"

"*They* know you love them," Adora reinforces softly, "You'll feel it. We just have to be patient."

Catra doesn't respond much, her tears dwindling a little as she sniffs. Adora wonders if now - strangely - is as good a time as ever to give her some hope, to let her know she isn't entirely frozen out of how their family is still forming. She reaches over for her rucksack on the back of the door handle, pulling out her purse to retrieve the grainy image.

"I promise, I really tried to tell you already. But I'm sorry I haven't yet."

"What's this?" Catra's understandably alarmed when she sees the sonograph photo and Adora's gut twists with worry that she's made the wrong decision in deciding to bring this up now, "Am I?..."

"Oh! No!" Adora curses herself for not making that clear to begin with, "It's me. You're not. I don't think you'd still be, anyway, if you were..."

Catra's blank, her spine stiff like cardboard as she speaks flatly, "Congratulations."

Adora doesn't know what reaction she honestly expected, but it isn't this. It's like Catra doesn't see herself in it at all.

"Well, it's congratulations' to you too," she ventures nervously, trying to keep her voice steady, "This is *our* future. All four of us."

Catra turns to her incredulously, and Adora can see her full comprehension of their situation sinking into her brain in real-time, "So. You're definitely keeping it?"

"Y-yeah. We waited a long time for this," Adora feels like she's doubly trapped in a nightmare, "It took three cycles of IVF for it to work."

Adora wishes she could see the excitement in Catra's irises spark like it had when they'd kissed over long-awaited positive results nearly four months ago. The life playing out now seems like a different universe altogether;she feels incomprehensibly stupid for ever hoping this conversation could have gone differently. Adora looks down at her lap and there's nothing she can do to stop her emotions spilling out - the dam that restrains every ounce of pain is bursting and she's powerless to stop it.

"Dor, stop, please," Catra sounds panicked, her hand rubbing circles on Adora's back like when they were in their early twenties and she had a breakdown over some terrible boss in her first architecture firm - it's a shadow of the intimacy they've built over the years, the aged softness of Catra's usual tone lost, "I didn't mean to make you cry. I...I've never done this before. I don't know what I'm supposed to say."

Adora thinks that there's not anything obvious Catra's *supposed* to say, but there's definitely a way that Catra's supposed to make her feel. It isn't going to help to point out that Catra *has* done all of it before - in fact, she's been the only person who could help Adora through the devastation of her struggle to conceive their second child.

"I shouldn't have assumed you'd be happy about it," Adora's voice dips so low that it's hardly a whisper, "But you've been so excited

about Finn, I thought. I kinda thought you'd see this as a second chance."

Catra's silent, and then she tugs Adora into her arms, pulling them onto the bed covers. She spoons Adora and lets her cry everything out, pressing her nose into Adora's shoulder. Slowly, she reaches down, her palm braced against Adora's stomach.

"It must have been a dream come true before," she says, pausing for a few moments before continuing, "Maybe it could be again. I want it to be."

Adora quietens herself to drink Catra's words in whole, the slightest pressure lifting from her shoulders.

"What else do you want?" It's fishing, and it's meek, but with Catra's hands firm on her body, Adora needs something more. She hopes her wife responds the same way she used to.

It's the greatest rush when she does - Catra shuffles apart from Adora and motions for her to meet her face-to-face. Adora can see the moisture glistening in her mismatched eyes and the clear concern that's clouding her expression. But she can also see desire, and longing, and all the things she hasn't even let herself think about how much she's missed.

Catra leans in, closing the distance between them. It's tentative to begin with, then tender before it's fierce, and it reminds Adora of the kisses that set her aflame at the start of them.

"Wow," Catra whispers, and she tucks the ends of Adora's bob behind her ear, "Was it always like that?"

"Yeah," Adora smiles, her hand moving up to cup Catra's jaw just like it had the very first time - though the thump of Catra's heartbeat against her skin means even more this time than it did before, "It always was."

Chapter End Notes

Yiddish dictionary (only accurate to UK English, other translations could differ)

Catraleh/bubbeleh - Adding 'leh' on the end is a term of endearment, and bubbeleh essentially means 'sweetheart'
Schlep - carry/haul/move something with effort
Tatti - father
Mame - mother
Meshuggeh - crazy
Mensch - good person (typically a man)
Ketching - complaining
Putz - idiot
Schmear - cream cheese, but also schmearing is a verb that is associated with spreading your topping properly on bread/bagels instead of skimping on the good stuff (if you're not in America, schmear is usually thicker than typical British or European cream cheese, you usually only get the proper stuff in kosher shops here)

I don't think I've ever written Catra with parents so this was a fun one... Would love to hear what you think of this, and also whether the pregnancy reveal/meeting with Finn went as you thought it might!

Next time, Catra finds out more about how much her life - and she herself - has really changed since she was younger.

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

> Hello everyone, and thanks for your patience!I've been absolutely snowed under at work so I've had less time to write since the weekend, but I hope this hits the spot.
>
> This is an important transitional chapter, though I did struggle to write it a little so that may come across. Either way, I really hope it lands well with you, and opens up a few more qestions as well as the ones it solves.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra doesn't think she's been this fed up in years. It's like every single day is an opportunity for someone to get on her nerves.

"For fuck's sake, Scorpia, can you hurry up?" Catra feels herself being stared down from the two crewmates in the driver's cab, but she's not about to give in this quickly, "There's no reason to be this slow and I've got a shit ton of paperwork to get on with."

"Chill," Lonnie says through gritted teeth, and Catra can tell the tension is starting to build between them again, "There's traffic."

Catra rolls her eyes, drumming her fingers on the back door handle of the ambulance. They're on their way back to base from a call-out - it felt like the billionth call that week where someone had overreacted to something so small that it probably didn't even merit an A&E visit.

"I'm going to murder these operators sometime soon. They used to vet this shit properly back-"

"Back when you were on the ground," Lonnie interrupts her with all the grace of a dump truck, "We fucking know, Catra."

It's almost hard to hold back a hiss at her junior's words; Catra's so irritable she could snap, and the sad thing is that it's been this way for months. Each shift weighs too heavily on her shoulders, her body winding tighter and tighter as the hours drag on. She'd never have imagined she'd feel like this at work in the past.

Catra feels like she could scream in frustration, and spends the rest of the ride digging her fingernails into her knee until they reach base. She pushes out of the back of the ambulance like a coil sprung hot, storming into her box room in the ambulance station and leaving the others to debrief. It's not professional, but it's better than exploding - she's learned that the hard way more than once.

The respite she gets in the dark of her room is sweet, and it just about makes up for the furore around her getting a private area in the first place. Catra's body aches from head to toe, and it's a relief now that she can finally discard the dampened pads in her bra and pump in peace, her eyes flitting over the reams of paperwork she's got to get through in the next couple of hours. She texts Adora to tell her she won't be able to pick up Finn from their childminder, and the only thing she feels grateful for is how accommodating her wife is. Adora's always been the type to wind everything up inside before she snaps - a fair contrast from the volatile simmer that roils for everyone to see on Catra's sleeve - but motherhood suits her wife far more than she expected. Besides the odd spot of fatigue, nothing seems to upset Adora much since Finn was born. Not like the way it upsets Catra.

Catra cradles her forehand in her hands, the points of her elbows drilling into her desk, as she thinks about the restless night she probably has ahead of her. She can feel the tears bleeding onto her fingers when-

"Boss?"

There's a knock on the door, but Scorpia appears before Catra gets a chance to respond anyway; it's a miracle she manages to pull her shirt over her chest in time at all.

“You need to knock, Scorpia,” Catra berates the other woman, though the pained expression on her face makes Catra feel a little guiltier than she’d like, “You can’t just barge in. I’m busy.”

“S-sorry, boss.”

“Well? What do you want?” Catra wipes the back of her hand on her face, hoping her sternness is enough to surpass the vulnerability her hormones have visibly wrought.

Scorpia seems to be at war with herself, figuring out what’s best to say. What she decides on isn’t what Catra wants to hear at all,“You don't look so good. Have you been getting enough sleep?”

“I’ve a six-month-old at home,” Catra glares at her, “Of course not.”

Quiet settles between them. Scorpia knows as well as anyone else that it had never been the plan for Catra to come back to work so soon. Yet her blood pressure had gotten too high to work after they’d moved house, and when one of Adora’s biggest clients went bust a month after Finn’s birth, Catra’s maternity pay didn’t top them up enough for her to stay home much longer.

“Maybe there’s something HR can do,” Scorpia ventures nervously, wringing her hands, “I know you’re doing your very best, but, oh boy, erm… there’s been a few instances that got folks talking, and-”

“Stop it,” Catra doesn’t even bother biting back her tears now. She has no pride left anyway, not after everyone’s witnessed her apparent descent from popular team lead to mercilessly moody manager. When she finally continues, she half speaks to herself rather than Scorpia, “I should have known it would be this hard, but I really thought I could do it. Prove myself to everyone! But I never stood a chance… Doesn’t matter what I do, turns out it all goes to shit anyway.”

She slumps in her stiff plastic chair, crossing her arms protectively over her chest as well as she can. The wheezing of pumping plastic

and dripping milk echoes against hard surfaces, and all Scorpia does is scratch the nape of her neck, scrambling to find something she can say back.

“Just go, Scorp, I got the memo. I’m a bitch and no-one likes me.”

“That’s not-!”

“Go!”

Catra doesn’t breathe until she’s finally alone. She mourns a little for the person she thought she was, who she can’t pretend is still the person she is. The ambulance crew at this station were her family for years - on the ground and in the sky - and Catra’s sure she’s permanently ruined any bonds she’d built. There’s only one person left who she knows will definitely try to understand, who’ll always have her back.

“Catra? Everything ok?” Adora answers on the first ring.

“Yeah, I- I just missed you. And Finn.”

“Aww, babe! I just got them home and down for a nap,” Catra can practically see the dopey smile on her wife’s face, but she’s exasperated by what Adora says next about their elderly childminder, “Syvia’s still using ‘he’ pronouns. And she brought up getting them baptised again.”

“Fuck, again? We need to find somewhere else for them to go, ‘Dor. I’ve spoken to her so many times about this shit.”

Adora hums under her breath, and Catra waits for the difficult conversation that usually signals.

“Unless we put them in Menorah-” Catra audibly objects to the idea of sending their baby to her parents’ synagogue nursery, but Adora shushes her with a forceful tone, “Which doesn’t help the religion

thing, I know - *we can't afford anywhere else. It'd be different if we only needed cover once or twice a week."*

"What about Bright Moon Beginnings?" Catra already knows the answer, but she wishes Finn could go to the inclusive kindergarten where many of their queer friends have placed their kids, "It's not as close, but…"

"It's too pricey without the local resident subsidy. And we've missed the 2019 intake anyway."

Catra sighs miserably. Their neighbourhood had amazing schools, but they hadn't originally realised quite how scarce affordable nursery placements were - particularly ones needed last minute.

"I don't want to rely on our parents more than we already are, Cat," Adora responds matter-of-factly, "We're just going to have to suck it up with Sylvia or Menorah. It's not like either of us can realistically go part-time."

Catra lets her wife's words sink in. She stares at the paperwork on the desk in front of her, and the empty greyness of the box room she'd been given to pump in. She wonders if this is still really what she wants; it certainly isn't what she envisaged her career in the air ambulance service would look like. There's not a single regret Catra has about having Finn, yet it's hard to reconcile her reality with the bittersweet memory of the job she used to love.

"What if I quit and look after them?" She takes a deep breath before justifying her offer, "I'm making peanuts compared to you and my salary hardly covers childcare costs anyway."

"What?" Adora's audibly shocked. Catra's a little shocked by it herself.

"'Dor, I'm miserable. And I'm making everyone else here miserable too."

“You didn’t say it was this bad,” Adora’s upset, and Catra wishes she hadn’t been so guarded about it until now, “You’ve always loved work. Maybe there’s a way we can fix it.”

Catra pauses, letting her wife’s soft encouragement soothe her before she finally fesses up. There’s so much she should tell her - the testimonies of postnatal depression she’s read and related more than she wanted to, the way her emotions seem to soar and plummet at a second’s notice, how she hates the shame she feels after every thoughtless snap or snipe at a colleague. Catra’s spent enough time wallowing in her denial to know now. Something really does have to give.

“Honestly, Adora? I don’t think I even want to fix it anymore.”

Catra curls up on her side under the duvet, willing herself to fall asleep. Six weeks have passed since she came to her and Adora’s home, but she can never work out if time is passing too quickly or much too slow.

Loving her wife openly is still a revelation. Every kiss and touch feels like it could make her heart and gut somersault at once - and don't even get her started on the sex. Catra knows she has a decade of lost orgasms to make up for, and when Adora’s hormones put her in the mood, she doesn't complain about putting in the hours.

Less easy is figuring out her relationship with her child - or children, if she grapples with Adora’s pregnancy too. The time she’s spent with Finn has been shaped by the schedule that hangs with a million stickers in the kitchen, a routine she’s only just realising she must have put in place herself. Catra goes through the motions as much as she can. Cuddles, story time, mealtimes, TV time, family time, park time... the list seems endless, and Finn’s increasingly frequent

tantrums drain Catra of every ounce of energy left in her bruised body.

Their disruptive behaviours are apparently something new, according to Adora, her in-laws and her parents. All six adults have been witness to numerous meltdowns now;screaming exasperation and reddening cheeks seem to be par for the course. It drives Catra away more than it should - she's startled by the anger and confusion she sees in Finn's tortured features and fists, so similar to those she's recognised in herself for as long as she can remember. Catra wonders whether it's their true nature coming out now that their happy family life's been corrupted by her memory loss. She hopes that's not all Finn has inherited from her.

Surely, by now, there's some good in me too?

Catra tries to remind herself that she has to have developed some redeeming features. Tantrums withstanding, the other version of her is surrounded by so much love from sources she never thought would provide it like this. If Catra's as truthful as she can be, it's all much weirder than she wants it to be. Since the first time they sobbed at her bedside in hospital, letting herself be gently embraced by her mother and father has become an unexpectedly regular occurrence;the terms Mame'and T atti'slip out more often than she would have expected. But when she watches Finn chatter with their bubbe and zayde, the Y iddish epithets falling easily from their lips, Catra cant figure out if she feels happy or sad. She struggles to make sense of how they could have gotten from point A to B. It's another magic switch that's been flicked since her last true memory - a fix she hadnt let herself hope for too much before - yet it feels empty. There's too much unresolved resentment sitting under her sternum to be truly happy, and everyone can tell.

Catra burrows her face into the pillows, her mind refusing to let her exhausted body drift off. If she doesnt manage to nap, there' s no way shell be able to do Finn' s bedtime routine - and given that Adora always has to run Finn's bath while Catra recovers her energy

and soothes her newly chronic headaches, she's determined not to miss it.

How else will everything become normal otherwise?

A few minutes later and she's completely resigned to her restless fatigue. Catra reaches to her bedside table for the blank iPhone her parents bought her a few weeks ago;everyone' s hope of restoring her lost phone and triggering new memories were utterly decimated when they realised that no one had any clue of Catra's iCloud password, or any of her back up security accounts. Instead, she's left with a few phone numbers she knows from 2011, photos she's taken when she's bored, and random apps that Adora told her they both use all the time (though Catra seriously questions why a period tracking app and a weekly meal planner are quite so integral).

She glares at her mobile, wishful to learn something new about herself that isnt distorted through someone else' s eyes. She goes to settings and types in every possible word she thinks her other self could possibly think of as important, swapping letters for numbers and asterisks for exclamation marks. It's no good.

"Fuck' s sake," Catra tosses her phone to the side, grunting as she hears it ricochet down the back of the bedside table instead of landing on the pillows. She twists round and stretches as far as she can to retrieve the phone, pulling it out of the narrow space until she notices a flutter of paper tickling her wrist. She manages to clamp two fingers around the edge of it as she draws her hand back;it' s a post-it note, blank except for the strangest combination of letters.

b17ds-f1sh3s-st4rs

It looks like some kind of unnecessarily overcomplicated WiFi password, invented by some provider's randomising software to maltreat anyone with the mildest diagnosis of dyslexia or dyscalculia. Or maybe…

Catra trembles as she fumbles with the mobile, blowing off the specks of dust it picked up behind the table and typing the code into her iCloud account.

"Oh my God!"

She's never been so excited, scared and relieved all at once to watch a piece of software update. Catra can barely breathe as she waits for the phone to download and update everything it needs to restore itself. This is it.

This is how I'm going to find out who I really am.

There's so much to explore that Catra doesnt know where to start. She figures she may as well do the boring things first, rather than starting with the texts and photos and being disappointed by everything else after. Catra pulls up her calendar, expecting to see her work schedule, or details about what she does at the weekend - maybe even if she has any friends she sees regularly who havent come up in conversation with Adora yet. But all she finds is regular board and committee meetings for the trustees of the Ambulance Service Trust, and a litany of kids' activities that look so far from anything she'd ever possibly want to do.

Even though it wouldnt seem it, Catra feels like the biggest thing of all has suddenly been revealed to her.

Who the fuck is this person? Why would I not be working at the base?

There's nothing for Catra to do but run.

She runs down the stairs, slipping silently past the half-ajar door of the bathroom where Adora's helping Finn to brush their teeth, and jams her bare feet into worn trainers.

She runs out the front door, shutting it behind her with force as she stumbles down the steps of their home onto the street.

She keeps running, her sprint hardly a jog after her first few steps, until she's so incredibly winded that it's all she can do to limp to the one place she prays has to still be the same as it always used to.

"Catra?"

She almost laughs: the ambulance base is exactly where she left it, and so's Bonnie, albeit with the odd silver hair gleaming in her dreads.

"Hey , are you okay?" Catra frowns at the uncharacteristic awkwardness her friend projects when she speaks to her , and the caution with which she's being approached. This isn't the Bonnie she knows, "Should you be here? I heard what happened in Elberon through the grapevine."

"Grapevine?" Catra narrows her eyes, "Aren't we friends?"

Bonnie shifts on the balls of her feet, "Things changed. Y ou got with Adora, and I met Ro and Kyle, and we didn't have much time outside of work anymore. When you came back after having Finn, things weren't so good before you quit. W e didn't stay in touch."

"I quit?" Catra reels from everything she' s hearing, but this really doesn't make any sense at all, "I left by choice?"

Bonnie steps back a little and watches her carefully - and Catra knows it's textbook for figuring out if someone's not doing too well mentally. She hates this pivot from care provider to patient;she isn't sure if she's ever felt so powerless.

"Should I call Adora? Does she know you're here?"

"I'm fine," Catra spits bitter lemons with her response.

"Y ou don't seem fine. "

Bonnie signals for her to sit on an eerily green cotton sofa - this kind of neon decor and furniture were definitely new - and Catra

begrudgingly complies, crossing her arms stubbornly as she pretends to ignore what Bonnie's saying to her wife. She rubs her thumb over the screen of her phone as she waits, not yet ready to resume her quest of self-discovery or acknowledge the careful questions Bonnie is intent on repeating at her .

When Adora bursts into the station, Finn miraculously perched on her hip despite her belly, Catra feels even worse. They're both clearly distraught - more so than Catra remembers seeing before.

"Cat!" Adora flies to her , setting Finn down on the sofa next to her and wrapping her arms tight around Catra's shoulders, "What happened? Are you okay?"

"Why does everyone keep asking me if I'm okay?" Catra snarls and breaks away from her wife, "Instead of telling me the truth?"

"The truth?" The penny drops when Adora notices Bonnie's apologetic expression.

"You lied to me," Catra replies, "Again. Am I going to find out I've got a fucking husband in Dryl next?"

"Catra!" Adora wraps her hand over Finn's ears, and it's so ludicrously pointless that Catra almost wants to laugh, "Outside, now . We're not doing this in front of them."

Catra sulks as Adora convinces Bonnie to watch over Finn, thanking her weakly for her congratulations about the baby. It's obvious for anyone to see now, and Catra wonders what others make of the ridiculous situation they've found themselves in. There's not much time to dwell on it though, she finds herself being tugged towards the exit and into the evening chill before she has a chance to object.

"I'm not going home, Adora. Not with you."

Catra hates the anxious wrinkle that forms between Adora's eyebrows when she hears it, but there's also a hint of gratification

that grows in her stomach. She isn't sure if she likes herself, knowing that's her response.

"Catra, you have to come home," Adora sighs like she's spent all day corralling sleepy teenagers into getting out of bed, "What is going on with you right now? You can't just run away like that, it's really upset Finn. And me."

Oh.

Catra didn't feel so good about that, despite her anger.

"Well," she scrambles for the right way to say this, to get her point across properly, but her anger spills out in a flood of acid instead, "Maybe it makes *me* upset to find out my wife's a corporate sellout and I'm some aimless stay at home mother."

"Cat-"

"Is that what you wanted all along? This stupid, fucking heternormative wet dream? Do I bake cookies for you? Make sure dinner's on the table when you come home?"

"That's not how it happened," Adora's speaking through gritted teeth now, teetering on the edge of losing control, "It was more complicated, and it wasn't supposed to be forever."

"Oh, great!" Catra barks with mirth, "Nice to hear I didn't give up on my literal dream career permanently. No wonder I lost my damn memory, I doubt there was anything of interest in my day-to-day to keep it in my fucking head!"

Catra's panting, her fury seeping out through every pore. But Adora doesn't respond the way she expects. She's cooled, pain locked up behind her eyes so no-one could ever reach it again.

"Finn needs to go to bed," she says, her tone entirely flat, "Come home when you're ready, now you've got everything off your chest."

Catra doesn't move for a good five minutes, not even when Adora comes outside with Finn again and bundles them into the car. She's practically paralysed, cast adrift between too many unwanted truths.

When they're gone, she huddles on the green sofa while Bonnie eats from her tupperware of leftovers, scrolling through her phone in a bid to find something - anything - that makes her feel better. She finds a whole other world that she'd never actually been able to imagine: selfies of herself pregnant and nursing, family photos of the three of them, a gazillion videos of first steps and first words, award ceremonies and fundraising dinners, and deep purple smudges smeared under tired, miserable eyes when she's wearing her old uniform.

Bonnie drives her home at the end of her shift a few hours later, insisting that Catra needs to eat and rest, however much she doesn't want to admit it. And then, it's just her and Adora, bundled up in blankets on opposite ends of the sofa, separated by a gulf of missing memories and spite.

"It wasn't trying to hide it from you," Adora says eventually, "I kind of thought you'd worked it out, what with Finn only being in daycare twice a week."

"How am I supposed to know that's normal? You're the one who keeps telling me that we're still figuring everything out."

"You're right. I'm sorry." Adora sighs then, running her hand through her hair, "I don't know why I didn't realise. Maybe I just didn't want to think about whether the current us are who the old us expected us to be. If that makes sense?"

"Yeah, I guess," Catra concedes, "I'm sorry for leaving and saying all that stuff too."

"It's okay. You should know everything, we can talk about it in the morning," Adora reaches out for her, and when she takes Catra's hand, it's like relief instantly flows through her veins, "Just please,

dont skip out on us like that again. I hate that you're going through so much - and I know I could be handling things so much better, I really do - but we have to find another way of dealing with all this."

Catra nods, but they're interrupted before she can come up with something to say. It's Finn, their head peeking cautiously round the living room door.

"What are you doing down here, munchkin?" Adora asks, and Catra's almost sore from the worry she can see on their child's face, "Your bedtime was hours ago."

"I cant sleep."

Catra braces herself for the screaming she guesses will start when Adora explains that they have to go back to bed, but she's surprised when Finn pushes their way into Catra's lap instead, their hair tickling the bottom of her chin as they snuggle into her chest. She feels warm for the first time that day, tightening her hold on them until she's cradling Finn in her arms.

"Are you gon' run 'gain?"

Catra's gotten a lot better at interpreting Finn's speech now;she notices there's a little bit of pride sparking in her chest when she doesnt have to ask them to repeat anything or look at Adora for help.

"No, honey-"

"Cos you're 'sposed to tell Mummy if you scared, not hide where we cants help."

"That' s a good point," she responds gently , cupping their face, "I'll make sure to remember that. But you could sleep a little here with me tonight if you want to."

Finn nods before they curl into her again, and Catra feels like her heart could burst. All she wants is to reassure them that things will get better. Even if she doesnt believe for herself, she has to believe it for her family.

"I love you," Catra says, because she wants so badly to feel it that she's lost the swell of a lie on her tongue - and maybe, when she feels the warmth of Finn's cheek under her palm, it's actually not entirely untrue, "More than there are birds in the sky."

"And fishies in the sea," Finn parrots back.

"And stars in the night."

Catra closes her eyes as she speaks, breathing in Finn's smell and imagining herself in the body of every version of herself she's met in her photos. She centres herself in the stretch of her abdomen and the suckle on her breast and the pride that was always tinged with worry on their first weeks of daycare;and how she's never felt surer of anything than she does in this moment that she could - *would* - love this child regardless of whether she ever remembers anything or not.

When her eyes finally flutter open, she sees Adora staring at her, shellshocked.

"How did you know that?"

Catra cocks her head and shrugs in question, her fingers threading through Finn's hair.

"The birds, the fishes and the stars," Adora's energy seems to rise with every word, "You couldnt possibly know"…

"Know what?"

"That's your thing, Cat. You and Finn, you always said it before bed. I've tried it a couple of times, but it's not the same coming from me."

Catra gasps, a blurred, muted vision of a hundred goodnights unfurling in the corner of her mind, "Did I..?"

"I think you remembered!Oh my God," Catra doesn't think she's seen Adora look so emotional before, "Cat. You remembered it."

"I remembered something," she muses, hope swelling in her chest for the first time since her diagnosis as she looks down at the sleepy child in her arms, "I remembered it for Finn."

Chapter End Notes

Well... what do you think will happen next?This was kind of a rocky one but at least things are starting to (potentially, lol) look up!So looking forward to hearing what you think - kudos and comments always hugely appreciated and treasured :)

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

Hi friends!Thank you so much for your patience while I somehow tore this out of my exhausted brain <3

Well, the tags have been updated to explicit so you can guess where this one goes... (at least before i stick the knife in again, sorry). This is the penultimate chapter and I have to figure out how to wrap this all up now!So buckle up for a wild - and hopefully satisfying - ride!

A big thank you to yoursfemmely, who helped me finalise the spice and make sure it reads exactly how it should 👃

You'll also see a gorgeous illustration at the start of the chapter from RaptorRed, who made my 2022 for gifting me a lovely artwork from this fic as part of the SPOP Flex secret solstice swap this December. It's the first artwork I've ever received of one of my fics so it meant an awful lot!I'm so glad to be able to share it with you here too :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes





It isn't often that Adora has time to be still these days, but as the summer breeze whips around her ears, she finally takes a second to breathe. It's noisy and crowded, and Finn digs a little into her bare arms with their fingernails, but she knows she'd not have missed this morning for anything. There's a swell of pride that pushes outwards from her chest when she watches her wife on the field, even if she misses the rush of blood and competition pumping through her own veins. But despite her initial objections, Adora doesn't regret

standing on the sidelines too much. She only has to recall the tease of Catra's smile and the familiar quirk of her eyebrow to know it'll be worth her while later.

"I'm going to play and you're going to watch," she'd told Adora, her irises swallowed by black, "And if you're lucky, I'll put on a show for you."

The firm press of Catra's finger on her bare sternum had shut her up quickly. Plus, training for the Bright Moon Ambulance Trust football tournament over the past few weeks has been good for Catra. Really good. Adora loves seeing the gleam in her eyes when she's just come home from practice. Finn giggles with joy when Catra scoops them up after, their fists twisting into the soft cotton of her sports fleece when she throws her head back in laughter. It's hard to believe how much has changed in a year - and the ease that Catra carries with her makes Adora feel like they can breathe again. It's still too easy to sink into guilt when she remembers how much Catra struggled after Finn's birth, and, worse, how little she'd noticed. It doesn't matter how many times she reassures herself, or how frequently her parents or Bow and Glimmer (or even Catra herself) tells her that Catra's better than anyone else at putting on a front. Adora has never fully shaken the belief that she let Catra down, too enamoured by their newborn to catch the depression taking hold. It's taking far more than vulnerable conversations and tender kisses for Adora to feel even halfway okay about it; for every hour of overtime she clocks in, her tendons aching from wrist to shoulder, Adora thinks about the liberation she's given her wife. She likes to think it's just as impactful as the pill Catra swallows every morning, that maybe working a little harder and a little longer to provide for the three of them actually can make up for it.

Adora can convince herself it's true when she watches Catra chatting with her fellow players, her shoulders shaking when she laughs at a joke that Adora can't fully hear but can tell is about her. She nuzzles into Finn, reflecting on how things might change again when Catra goes back to work - she's already stepped in to run

training workshops for a few struggling bases, and has just been appointed as a trustee of the Ambulance Trust. It's clear from their awkward interactions at the start of the game that Catra hasn't really resolved things with her former crew mates, but Adora's relieved that facing their team in the final match of the tournament isn't throwing her wife off at all. If anything, it only seems to make Catra more determined to have a good time.

Adora thinks she's having a pretty good time too, until a shout knocks her out of her thoughts.

"Like what you see, Greyskull?"

Catra shoves Netossa on the shoulder lightly despite the satisfied grin blooming on her face. Adora's cheeks redden fast but she can't object much - she's been blatantly ogling her wife all morning.

"Hey, it's a family event, Net," Catra admonishes her fellow trustee, "Have some respect."

Netossa snorts, "Wouldn't know it by the look on her face."

Adora rolls her eyes, but she can't stop her excitement building when Catra winks at her slyly, jogging over to kiss Finn on the forehead and lean in close to her ear.

"Told you I'd make watching worth your while…"

Adora gulps, squeezing Finn a little harder in her arms when they chortle, their delighted shrieks rising above the hubbub of the crowd. There's a few seconds that freeze between the three of them before Catra's off again; at the pierce of a whistle, her attention is focused so singularly on the ball spinning at her feet that Adora can't help but marvel at her wife's determination. It's impossible not to appreciate Catra's form, strong tendons working hard underneath the newfound softness she loves gripping between her palms. Adora feels like she could get lost in memories of exploring Catra's body over the years; every sharp turn of her ankle evokes the sensation of Catra's foot

rubbing up her calf under the sheets, and the desperate heave of her chest looks just like it does after they resurface from oxygen-starved kisses.

“Look, Finny! Mama’s got the ball!”

Catra gets the ball to the other end of the pitch before she passes it to Glimmer, jumping into the air with satisfaction when their friend manages to shoot it right past the goalie’s outstretched palms into the net. The crowd roars and Adora screams too, hoisting Finn higher up on her hip as they squeal in excitement.

“They’re going to be unbearable after this, aren’t they?” Bow’s voice booms beside Adora.

“Thank God it’s only for charity,” she agrees, “Can you imagine if they played in a real league tournament?”

“Says the most competitive woman on planet Earth.”

Adora shrugs in assent to Bow’s wry response, adjusting Finn’s sun hat and pressing her lips to their cheek. She catches Catra’s eye briefly as she jumps in the air triumphantly with her teammates, her expression softening at the sight of their kid. Adora knows that look; it’s appeared increasingly often over the past couple of months.

“Do you think we’re ready?” It’s no surprise when hours later, Adora lets Catra’s voice wrap around her ears as she sits between her wife’s legs in the bath, steamy water lapping at their thighs, “Not to start right away, but…”

Her voice trails off and all Adora can hear is the suck of a wet sponge on her shoulder and the measured exhale behind her; the trickling of water against skin echoes on the bathroom tiles, a welcome reminder of the rare quiet in their home.

“I should be the one bathing you,” Adora says instead of answering her wife’s question, “You’re the one who was on the pitch.”

Catra hums and even though Adora knows she's giving her time, she also knows that Catra isn't so easily fobbed off.

"I've got more on my mind than this," she replies, and Adora can practically see the smirk on Catra's face through the back of her head as the coil at her core tightens, "I told you I'd give you a show, didn't I?"

"Hmm… I'm still waiting…"

Catra's outraged scoff comes just as expected - yet when a surge of water crashes against Adora's hips and an arm reaches around her, she's taken by surprise.

"Cat! What are you d-?"

She quietens promptly when Catra's fingers hover right below her navel, arching her head into Catra's collarbone urgently.

"You want more of a show, huh?" Catra's voice is shallow, her breaths already quickening when she moves her hand lower, her other wrapping around to palm Adora's breast. She chuckles lightly when Adora pulls her thighs up instinctively and her knees fall out against the sides of the tub. "Let's see if I can entertain you…"

Adora moans as her breast is kneaded and nipple is pinched, only silenced when Catra's slickened fingers pause their stroking of her labia to clamp over her mouth.

"Shhh," Catra teases, nibbling on her lobe, "Finn'll be a nightmare tomorrow if they don't sleep. Besides, we don't want to get distracted by any little interruptions, do we?"

The hand on her mouth is enough to make Adora whimper under her wife's hold, and she bites down hard on her lip to quiet herself. When Catra praises her, she feels her cum pooling; she almost cries with relief when Catra returns her attention to where Adora really wants it. The bathwater crashes against white porcelain and her hips begin to

buck once Catra picks up speed, the randomised touch building tension faster than Adora expects. Her mouth opens in a soundless scream, every inch of her body begging for relief when her wife sucks on the side of her neck and finally circles Adora's clit. When Catra grabs the side of Adora's waist to pull her closer and she feels her wife's hips twitch behind her, she seizes Catra's thigh in return, her fingertips pressing purpling crescents into her skin. Her quivering body held in total hostage under Catra's touch, Adora gasps for air until electricity courses boldly through her. Her back arches away from Catra's pebbled nipples and further into her hands as she comes undone.

"Good girl." Catra's almost as breathless as Adora is but she doesn't stop, only easing her pressure between Adora's legs as she comes down, "I always look after you, don't I?"

Adora's head lolls back on Catra's shoulder, and she revels in how her wife's chest rises and falls in tandem with her own. In the throes of life, it's been weeks since Catra was this dedicated to Adora's desire; it's simultaneously reassuring and exhilarating to feel the evidence that Catra's wanted to pleasure her all this time - but it also reminds Adora of what they've had to overcome.

"I'm scared," Adora's words spill from her lips unexpectedly, her mental barriers destroyed by her spent state.

"Scared?" Catra's confused and her hold around Adora loosens a little, her palms retracting back to her hips, "'Dor, I'm sorry, did I-?"

"No! No," Adora clamps her hands around Catra's and hurries to make it clear she's had no problem whatsoever with their bathtime fun, "I… I know it's stupid and you can never control these things really, but what if it happens to me too? Like if I get depressed after the birth? Or if you go back to work while I'm off and it's too much, and it ruins everything? You've been doing so well and I'm so proud of you, and I don't want to be the reason we don't have another kid but I also don't want us to-"

“Hey,” Catra cuts off Adora’s spiral gently, rubbing soothing circles on her stomach, “It’s okay. We can plan for every possible eventuality if it makes you feel better. And there’s no rush if you’re not ready.”

Adora knows logically that what Catra says is true, but if they want Finn to have a sibling close in age, it’s also not.

“I want to be.” Adora doesn’t recognise the timid tinniness of her own voice.

“Then we can talk about it. But ‘Dor? I really don’t think there’s anything that we couldn’t get through together.”

Catra’s words are soft and firm and secure all at once, and Adora doesn’t think there’s anywhere she’d feel safer than she does cradled in Catra’s arms. It’s easy to agree - after everything, what could possibly shake them now?

Everything aches and it never stops but Adora will be damned before she lets on. She’s managed perfectly well dealing with everything alone these past seven months and she’s become strangely determined to prove that she can do this - to Catra, Finn, their parents and friends, even *herself* .

"Three more weeks,"she mutters under her breath before she slowly heaves herself out of the bath with effort. She'd promised Catra that morning she wouldn't try getting in and out of their tall-sided tub without anyone nearby but Adora’s been feeling maddeningly obstinate all day.

Bite me, she thinks, gripping the edge of the bath with one hand and fixing the other flat against the tiled wall, *Why is everyone still enabling her anyway?*

Her bravado stutters when she stumbles stepping over the porcelain walls of the standalone tub, her hip banging painfully against the towel rack as her foot skids on the bath mat.

"Fuck!" Adora cant stop the panicked shriek from escaping her as her spike pulses, her hand snapping instinctively to her bump once she'd steadied herself.

That could have been bad, Adora thinks, her mind running amok with thoughts of Catra and Finn finding her on the puddled bathroom floor, or worse, of the storm in her belly stilling. It's annoying how much she wishes Catra was in the bathroom with her now, despite her underlying frustration. Even as she lowers herself carefully to perch on the edge of the tub, her feet planted wide and firm for stability, memories of her wife in this bathroom make it harder to maintain her irritation. How many times had Catra kneeled before her in this very spot with a needle trained over her abdomen, coaxing her through the phobia that had become their biggest emotional barrier to renewed parenthood?

Was it really her if she doesn't remember it?

Adora's old Catra had been her rock, but the Catra she has now doesnt truly know this;no matter what Adora tells herself or how many times she repeats their stories, it's impossible for Catra to feel it.

You're ungrateful. You should count your blessings.

When Adora remembers how her Catra would come to her rescue and wipe her tears away, calloused hands grounding and soothing her amidst her pain, there's no stopping the guilt from crashing through her.

"It' s not her fault," Adora whispers to herself, though it' s gotten harder to take comfort in her mantra as the months have flown by, "She'll come back."

She gives herself one minute, maybe two, before she brushes it off and gets dressed. At least this is something she can do mindlessly, her actions mechanical and practical. Going through the paces has become a relief: underwear, leggings, t-shirts and jumpers go on in their layers, stretching over her mottled skin like soft armour, miraculously dependable as she grows. Once that's done, the real work starts. Adora gazes at herself in the mirror, studying how she can fortify the mask she's been crafting meticulously for weeks. She's perfected the art of embellishing her face with smiles and laughter and worn wrinkles at the corner of her eyes on demand. It's almost second nature to force a spark in her irises when she focuses on the messy curls bouncing around Finn's scalp or the jolt of a tiny, restless foot bruising the inside of her ribs.

Sure, it's easy to play the role of content wife and mother when everyone around her marks up the tremble of her bottom lip to hormones. In these shows of misdirected support - when there's a hand gripping her shoulder or rubbing gentle circles into the back of her palm - Adora pretends that she's genuinely being consoled for her losses. Sometimes in these distorted moments, Adora loses her ability to escape the truth and it swallows her whole: she's utterly consumed by her grief for a person who never died. She grieves for a wife who still reaches out for her in the dead of night under the duvet, who massages shea butter into her stinging stretch marks, and shifts her weight from foot to foot as she works to unfurl the knots in Adora's shoulders. Catra is here, she's *alive*, and yet…

Adora's repeated reassurances to Catra seem to do their job but they ring hollow in her own chest. She's said the first part so many times - *you're the same Catra you always were* - but she'd never dare to voice the second, not even to her own ears.

Somehow you're not quite mine.

Adora exhales, straining to hear Catra and Finn playing in the garden through the open bedroom window. There's shrieks and laughter hidden under the muffled rumblings of a distant plane overhead, and Adora can imagine the joy bouncing off their faces in

the sun. It’s everything she ever dreamed of, though it’s strangely foreign now. Her wife and child live in a cocoon of restored memories;Catra’ s desperation to unlock more memories has driven her deep into the world of their first-born, hours spent uttering familiar phrases and revisiting once-favourited outdoor spots. To begin with, Adora loved Catra’s newfound determination. Her heart would surge with every glimmer of excitement bubbling through Catra’s features, hanging on her wife’s every word as she waited to hear what treasured memory had resurfaced next. Now, though…

Now Adora’s gut sinks when she listens, knowing that the younger version of herself drifts further and further away from them with every vision that doesnt include her . She warps through time, her body distorting beyond recognition in comparison to the Adora she wishes Catra could see in her mind’s eye.

When she thinks of the excited fervour that swept Catra up when planning Finn’s fourth birthday party but has never translated to any scan or midwife visit or long-awaited unboxing of tiny baby clothes, it’s near impossible to ignore her latent dismay.

She groans as a dull ache wraps around her hips - it’s almost nice to have something that’s annoying enough to distract her from her waning hope - and fights off the exhaustion threatening to claim her to amble into the nursery. Picking up the screwdriver and hammer is another act of unnecessary stubbornness, but Adora’s desperate to feel in control of something. Tools have always made her feel powerful. It’s not long before Adora’s so entrenched in the clout of her hammer against wood that she hardly notices footsteps coming up behind her.

“Dor?Y ou’re meant to be napping!”Catra sounds worried despite the sternness of her words, “What are you doing?”

Adora barely glances at her wife, though her brow furrows at the pull of muscles in her back and thighs that she probably shouldnt have pushed to old pre-pregnancy limits, “What does it look like?Im building the cot.”

"You shouldn't be doing that! Besides, I wanted to help."

"I'm *fine*," Adora grits her teeth, "just let me get on with it."

"You're not fine."

"I *am* fine! Just carry on with Finn and I'll come find you both when I'm done, alright?"

Suddenly, Catra's filling up Adora's entire eye line; the outline of her shoulders and hair ripple as Adora struggles to repress her tears and maintain her flimsy composure. Catra reaches out cautiously, her palm positioned perfectly by Adora's jaw. It's impossible for Adora not to lean into her wife's touch, and when she makes eye contact, she sees that Catra looks just as scared and exhausted as she does.

"I'm sorry. I just can't help missing you," Adora admits, her resolve disintegrating, "I know I'm not supposed to but I do."

Catra's face twists in confusion before it gives way to disappointment. The sight is galling and Adora rushes to fill the sore silence between them, willing herself to make things better rather than worse.

"I'm so happy you remembered being pregnant with Finn and what they were like when they were little. But you've been kind of hyper fixated on them ever since, and I..." Adora winces when she's interrupted by a sharp twinge, "it's like I'm doing all this alone."

"Adora-"

"Maybe I shouldn't have done so much of the nursery without you already," Adora pushes past Catra's interruptions, desperate to finish her wild train of thought before she loses steam, "look, Cat, I need something that's good for this baby. I can't sit around watching you chase your memories any longer."

Adora can't bear to look at Catra properly. The tremble in her wife's voice confirms that she's just as hurt as Adora feared she'd be.

"I... I thought you wanted me to remember us. I'm trying to be the way I was."

"I know," Adora feels sick, like she's opened a can of worms she is completely unequipped to deal with, "But it's been nearly three months since your memories of Finn returned. Maybe we just need to accept that nothing else's going to happen. Start afresh."

Catra shakes her head, "I don't want to start afresh. I want to remember us."

"Catra, I'm due at the end of the month! We have to be realistic-"

Adora's skin prickles coolly when Catra rips away from her, her features crumpling in real time. Catra storms out the room and Adora's alone, waiting with baited breath. Her heart races, picking up speed until she hears Catra mumbling to their kid in the next room and the sound of Finn's favourite television programme seeps through the wall. When Catra slinks back into the nursery, her body's wound tighter than Adora's seen it in years. She waits for Catra to say something but all she does is stare at the floor, her brain working overtime.

"Say something," Adora begs, "Anything."

Catra shakes her head. She finally looks back at Adora like she's crazy, like she'll never understand the great injustices of the world.

"Did I ever tell you before," she finally gives voice to her inner thoughts, "How long I'd waited to tell you how I felt?"

Adora nods, yet it doesn't escape her that to Catra, her assent reveals another uneven keel of knowledge between the two of them. She stays quiet, figuring it's best to make space for Catra to continue.

"It took me years to realise how I felt about you. So much time we could have spent together, gone. And then I fast-forwarded to this?" Catra's speech dips as her voice splinters and betrays her devastation, "It isn't fair! You got to live it all but I skipped everything. So sue me if it's taking too long to figure out my shit!"

"Catra, please. I'm sorry ." Adora reaches out for the brunette but Catra doesn't step forward to close the gulf between them. "I didn't mean to upset you."

"I'm always upset."

Catra sinks to the floor, her back slumping against the wall opposite Adora. She looks up at her, and Adora's silenced by the exhaustion in her pupils when she peeks through her wayward waves.

"I used to practice in the mirror when you were out, you know . I'd tell myself 'It's now or never', and figure out what to do in every worse case scenario. I'd even looked up room listings in case I ruined everything and you didn't want to live with me anymore," Catra sniffs, her hands coming up to hide her face, "I know it all worked out in the end. You married me. But I don't think I really believe it - there's just so many gaps between us. I hate it."

Adora feels like the most obvious penny in the world is finally dropping in her brain.

"You don't have those gaps with Finn."

"No. They're..they're the only person I know that I'm fully there with. I'm not… *incomplete* to them. I'm just Mama."

"You're not incomplete to me, Catra," Adora's heart hurts so badly for Catra, she hardly feels able to speak, "I love you, more than anything."

"I'm hurting you. At the worst time."

Adora pushes herself forward with effort and crawls across the carpet. It's her turn to cup Catra's jaw now , stroking her thumb over the smooth planes of her honeyed cheek and catching her wife's tears on her fingertips.

"It doesn't make me love you any less." She leans in to press a kiss to Catra's forehead and murmurs against her temple, "When I got that call after the accident, I didn't think I'd survive if we lost you. I'd love you the same even if you didn't have any recollection of me or Finn at all. But I need you to take a breather. If the memories come, they come, but right now I just need us to look ahead for a bit, okay?"

I need to practice what I preach, Adora thinks, reflecting on her own bitterness, *we've no chance of making it if we're both tied up in the past.*

"Okay ," Catra replies shakily after a long pause, her hand moving to tenderly cover Adora's own, "I'll try , I promise."

Adora nods, capturing Catra's lips after she wipes away the last of her tears. She wishes she hadn't become so sullen over recent weeks, or that she'd stopped herself from letting the bridge between them bow under the pressure of her resentment. It's sweeter than expected when Catra closes the gap between their bodies and guides Adora to a more comfortable position, her palms melding to the small of Adora's back and the expanse of her belly as they move. It's a gesture of solidarity that shouldn't mean much yet swallows them whole with its magnitude.

For the first time in weeks, they find an inkling of something pure they've never needed more: hope.

Chapter End Notes

I can't believe there's only one more update to go until this is finished!

I hope this chapter seemed like a purposeful bridge, I've honestly super struggled with figuring out how to wrap up this and my other WIP. Any feedback/comments you'd like to share would be massively appreciated :)

If you'd like something to read while I navigate my various existential crises/try not to burn at the stake of capitalism while I attempt to hit my work sales targets, you can explore these lil babies of mine:

- Where it happens... (messy exes/deaf Catra AU, final chapter coming soon)
- In Her Shoes (Cher-driven festive one-shot, essentially useless lesbians do Freaky Friday/Your Name)
- The Pact (if you enjoy the themes of pregnancy/motherhood/loyalty/grief that also come up in this fic, then you might like this completed multi-chapter melodrama. It's definitely my darkest and most complex read with a lot of trigger warnings, but also my favourite)

Also writing a lil golem one-shot atm, so keep an eye out for some folklore fic vibes coming your way...

Epilogue

Chapter Notes

> Here's the final chapter - an epilogue, so slightly different vibe and format from the rest of the fic. I've tried to make up for all the angst with a hefty portion of fluff for dessert!I'm travelling for work soon to deliver on my big yearly (time-consuming and stressful) project, so really want to get this one served for ya before I'm off.
>
> Grateful to everyone who has read along and kindly fed me with kudos and comments!I'll be extra appreciative of any more you have to give.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

THREE WEEKS

Catra knows it's a bad idea, but goddammit, Adora is stubborn as hell sometimes. Catra asks her wife over and over again if she's alright or uncomfortable and if they can finally give up on going out. But of course, Adora isn't having any of it.

"It's your birthday, Catra," she insists, "We do this every year and there's no reason to stop now."

Against her better judgement, Catra watches as Adora struggles to pour herself into something other than overstretched leggings and bundles herself into the car, giving Glimmer and Bow strict instructions not to let Finn have ice cream for dinner (whatever they claim their mothers have said). Yet once they're crammed into high backed chairs with a sparse menu to browse, it's suddenly clear why Adora's making such a big deal of the evening. She's determined to order the same dishes they apparently always do, and sit at the

same corner table. For all the times Adora has begged Catra to focus on the future recently, she's obviously desperate to induce a memory that could trigger everything else coming back. So Catra humours her and squeezes her hand, and pretends the Gruyère soufflé she's been told is her favourite starter blows her mind just as much as Adora wants it to.

Slowly but surely, Catra notices the flinch her wife fails to suppress between sentences. After the third time Adora refuses to admit that they should leave, Catra tells her they're skipping dessert and to wait while she goes to the front desk and pays, end of conversation. Still, she's surprised when she hears a long, loud groan from across the restaurant floor and realises quite how deluded her wife is.

When they get to the car and reality cracks, all hell breaks loose. Adora sobs and writhes and whimpers, and for the first time in nearly six months, Catra feels unexpectedly useful.

They're caught in a muddle of red and purple, and it's not what they planned but it's just the two of them - three, even, by the time it's over - and there's sweat plastered all over Adora's skin against the darkened passenger seat. Catra remembers every detail of what she's supposed to do;not just her first respondent's training, but how Adora can be calmed between pushes with reassuring mantras and a firm palm on her thigh. It's second nature to hold the space with expertise when she talks her panicked wife through every positive reaction the newborn has to her checks, and explains what will happen when they finally make it to the hospital.

Amidst all her resurging knowledge, Catra feels powerful - and most of all, it's because of Adora. Her wife's done something she didnt think she could, and Catra got to be the one to see it. Not the old Catra who got to live every other blessed moment of their love story. *Her.*

This Adora belongs to her and her alone.

"I love you," Catra says, and when she stops to gaze at Adora with her trembling feet on the dashboard and dishevelled hair and squirming babe at her breast, she doesn't think it's possible she ever felt this love so potently, even in the before times.

"I love you too," Adora says back immediately, her pupils blown wide with adrenaline before she glances down disbelievingly at her chest, "And you three."

THREE MONTHS

Adjusting to parenthood with two kids shouldn't be the perfect time to return to work, but for Catra, it turns out it is. Her fears that she isn't stable or sharp enough to dive back into her old job prove to be unfounded; before she knows it, it's two months since she stepped back into the refurbished base with its lurid green furniture and forgotten grudges between old colleagues. When she's up in the air with the violent whip of rotor blades pulsing over her skin, Catra feels like she can breathe better than at any other time.

She's good at coming up with solutions in a crisis - in fact, Catra's even more skilled at it than she remembers being a lifetime ago. Her memories of call-outs and training courses have unfurled in drifts, earned experience emerging as she needs it. It's hard to believe there was a time when she hated this job enough to leave it, but Catra's grateful for what she's been able to rebuild. She's learned that regained accomplishment is a sweet feeling, especially when it always takes her back to Mara's birth.

She's learned somehow, too, to let go of her possessiveness of Finn. Instead of her focus narrowing, Catra's found her capacity for love

has only grown with their second child. It helps that she's finally agreed to let Finn attend her parents' synagogue nursery before they start primary school;when she picks Finn up and takes them home to Adora and Mara, it feels like everything comes full circle.

Adora, for all her credit, is settling into maternity leave better than either of them expected. She's exhausted and sore but she's also learning to relax and let Catra step up. Their partnership feels more balanced than it has since Catra woke up in hospital;in giving less of herself, Adora's made enough room for Catra's agency to grow. When they huddle in bed for Mara's night feeds, it's easy for Catra to feel a full part of their little family. She's not lacking, or broken. She's finally herself.

THREE YEARS

There's no need to worry that they've given Mara an unsuitably gendered name. On her third birthday, it's clear their mischievous daughter is as stereotypically girly as any sparkly toddler can be;she wants nothing more but to play with her mothers' hair and declare herself grand princess of their home, wreaking havoc at any moment she can.

Dressed up in their finest birthday regalia as per the toddler's demands, Catra holds Mara in her arms. Adora mans the barbecue and Catra revels in the soft pressure of little hands clinging to her shoulders and a face nuzzling into her neck, even if she has to wear a matching tiara against her will.

"Is it time to eat yet, Mum?" Another young voice pipes up from the grass calling out for Adora, "I'm hungry!"

Finn skips and cartwheels on the lawn and Catra has to lunge, birthday girl in tow, to stop them from hurtling into the grill.

"Careful there, honey!" Adora steadies them all, her flaxen hair shining in the golden sunlight, "I didn't put chargrilled Finn on the menu for Mara and Mama's birthday!"

"I don't know, Dor. I can imagine Finn is *absolutely delicious*!" Catra teases a squeal out of the seven-year-old. She sets Mara down on the grass and tickles both her children as Adora watches on, pretending to chomp at their bellies as they squirm with delight. Her babies are unbelievably loud when they're being this silly, but her previous statement isn't wrong. They're sweeter than the chocolate cake waiting for lit candles in the kitchen.

"No, Mama!" Finn screams with laughter at Catra's touch, "You're supposed to love me, not eat me!"

"Hmm, you make a good point." Catra sits back on her heels, ruffling her first-born's hair, "I do love you rather much."

"More than there are birds in the sky!" Mara scrambles into Catra's lap, parroting the words she's heard every night since she was born.

"And fishies in the sea," Finn adds with familiarity, their eyes crinkling with pleasure.

Catra nods in affirmation, catching Adora's ridiculously sappy expression before she turns back to their children, "And stars in the night."

It might not be what she imagined when she first woke up in hospital, but Catra can't envision life for their excitable family of four being any other way.

THREAD

Maybe it isnt worth the hassle, but Catra likes getting her greys dyed. She doesnt feel her full sixty-four years - to be fair , she doesnt remember living all of them. Nevertheless, she always purses her lips smugly when her Paramedical Science students at Bright Moon University exclaim in surprise upon learning she’s got grandchildren - two of them, even - and that her youngest kid’s already thirty herself. It’s only sometimes that the toll life’s taken on Catra’s body catches up with her.

Today’s been one of those days. She notices the dull ache in her wrist when she taps on her laptop and the creak in her lower back during a practical demonstration. When Catra reschedules her office open hours to get her hair done and go home early, she doesnt like to think too much about whether her punitive schedule should continue to stay the same.

It isnt until she walks in on Adora alone in the kitchen and her wife looks up in surprise at Catra's unexpectedly early entrance, that everything shifts on its axis. Adora’s wearing an expression Catra doesnt recognise but seems so familiar , like second hand shoes already broken in. As always, there’s splinters of memory that hang in the forefront of Catra’s mind and tease her - but this time, suddenly, clarity breaks through.

‘I want to make pancakes for dinner ,’’she blurts out without thinking, and the words feel so right - so *important* - that it’s like Catra’s been waiting to say them forever.

Adora’s jaw drops and she stands from her stool at the kitchen island, almost as fearful as she is surprised. She moves closer but Catra holds her hand up between them like she’s unearthing something fragile from the bottom of her soul.

“And..and I wanna watch TV with you forever , even if it’s under the covers when you’re sick.”

There’s two Adoras standing before her now. One young and unsure, and another who’s weary with wrinkles but reaches out with such certainty that Catra finally pushes herself forward into her arms. Catra can feel tears pooling in the corners of her eyes. She’s sure it happened exactly the same the first time.

“You were wearing that old red jumper and I was in my uniform,” she tells her, “And when you kissed me back, it felt so good I thought I was hallucinating.”

“Tell me I’m not hallucinating right now,” Adora’s breaths are quick and shallow, and she laughs disbelievingly under her breath, “I didn’t think this was possible after so long.”

Catra’s breath stops and she can’t stop herself from surging forward and pulling Adora even closer. She kisses her firmly, the softness of her wife’s aged body in her arms blending with the ghost of her younger self’s muscular torso. Her love isn’t any deeper or surer - for Catra, Adora has always been her North Star, even when she thought their relationship was platonic - but there’s peace in knowing how their love story first unfolded for herself.

She remembers, too, how much she’d been overtaken by fear that day, her heart clenching in her rib cage at the thought of losing Adora, whether through death, rejection or otherwise. It seems incredulous that she could have ever lost her now. Catra’s got proof in spades - she could lose whole eras of life before she’d ever lose Adora.

When Adora leans her forehead against Catra’s and kisses her again, softer and more tenderly, Catra can sense her wife’s relief. Her fingers travel the same route up Catra’s neck and jaw that they did the very first time, and then she says it, just like they both remember.

“Pancakes for dinner, then?

“Yeah,” Catra grins, a whirlwind of memories enveloping them in tandem, “Sounds good.”

Chapter End Notes

Thank you so much for reading, and hope you enjoyed the ending! I would love to hear your thoughts.

I've posted the first chapter of my golem AU, Heart of Stone, and hope to have the second installment written over the next month.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!